



Maono PS22 Lite

The budget audio interface that might just surprise you

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You've got a great microphone. You've got ideas flowing. You're ready to record your podcast, music, or stream – until you realize your audio sounds thin, noisy, or just plain bad. The missing piece? A reliable audio interface. That's where the Maono PS22 Lite USB Audio Interface steps in. I got my hands on it at the Digit Test Centre and put it through its paces – recording vocals, instruments, and streaming live. At just \$69.99, does it deliver the goods, or should you save up for a pricier option? Let's break it down.

Build and Design

Straight out of the box, the Maono PS22 Lite feels lightweight yet durable. The matte black finish gives it a professional look, and the controls are neatly arranged

for ease of access. On the front panel, you get a single XLR input with 48V phantom power support, making it compatible with both condenser and dynamic microphones. The gain knob offers up to 56 dB of preamp gain, ensuring clean and warm audio capture. Next to it, there's a dedicated instrument input.

The interface also features a dynamic LED light ring that serves as a visual indicator for audio levels. The side-mounted headphone monitoring port is a nice touch. The USB-C port on the rear allows for plug-and-play connectivity with Windows and macOS.

Features

Despite its budget-friendly price tag, the PS22 Lite comes packed with useful features. The 24-bit/192kHz high-resolution audio ensures clear and detailed recordings, making it suitable for professional use. The 106 dB dynamic range means less background noise and a more natural sound profile. One of its biggest highlights is the ProStudio Routing Software, which enables virtual channels, loopback functionality, and ASIO driver support for low-latency streaming and recording.

For musicians, the dedicated instrument input with adjustable impedance allows for direct recording without the need for additional gear.

Another useful addition is the direct monitoring feature, which ensures zero-latency monitoring, letting users hear their audio in real-time without any delay.

Performance

Performance-wise, the Maono PS22 Lite delivers beyond expectations for its price point. The preamp gain is strong, capturing vocals with clarity and warmth. During podcast recordings, voices sounded rich and well-defined, with minimal background noise. The 48V phantom power worked seamlessly with condenser mics, providing enough power for crisp audio capture. For live streaming, the loopback function proved to be a valuable tool, allowing easy integration of background music and other audio sources without additional software. The ASIO driver support ensured smooth performance on DAWs like Ableton and FL Studio, making it a solid choice for music production as well. Instrument recording was equally impressive. The direct input for guitars produced clean, detailed sound without noticeable distortion, and the built-in effects added a layer of polish to the final output. However, at high gain settings, there was a slight noise floor, though it was manageable.

Verdict

After testing the Maono PS22 Lite, it's clear that this USB audio interface offers incredible value for money. The combination of high-resolution recording, flexible routing software, and solid preamp performance makes it a strong contender in its category.

However, it does face competition from established options like the Focusrite Scarlett Solo, which offers slightly better preamp quality. But for beginners, podcasters, and live streamers looking for an affordable and feature-packed interface, the PS22 Lite is a fantastic choice. Overall, if you're in the market for a budget-friendly audio interface with pro-level features, the Maono PS22 Lite is well worth considering. **d**